

searches for the month, and includes several categories. The monthly Zeitgeist format has changed over the years, and as of right now, it's divided into regular searches, news searches, and image searches. Under the regular searches, we find, for the month of August 2006, "Music to my ears" (bands), Songbirds (female singers), European soccer, and "Unpleasant Revelations?", each of which has five top searches listed under it. Under that last link, for example, we found "Dell Battery Recall."

This categorisation changes every month, and is a sort of complete, final, compiled report of what the times were like at a particular point. So, for example, under July 2006, we find no "songbirds" category; instead, we find links to "summer travel," "Web 2.0," and Movie and TV searches.

Then, since much of the Internet is still American, you'll be interested in the "Zeitgeist By Country This Month," where Google "regularly updates Zeitgeist by Country to reflect tidbits of information relating to the searches made by Google's global community of users. We add more countries as we can, so check back often." India is on the list, so you can see what Indian searchers were searching for, by month.

By Year

The year-end Zeitgeist (for 2005, of course) is currently at www.google.com/intl/en/press/zeitgeist2005.html. Visit the tabs—search terms are listed, and there are interesting graphs that, like in Google trends, reflect the correlation of events with searches. The tabs here are World Affairs, Nature, Movies, Celebrities, and Phenomena. (It's different each year. This is for 2005.)

The things you get here are little article-like snippets. For example, under Phenomena, there's a comparative graph of searches for "iPod," "mp3," and "podcast," and it says:

"Cognoscenti may know that MP3 is the audio file format everyone is using to hear and share music, but the name of a certain company's device that such files are played on is even easier to remember. Apple's

iPod inspired another new term: podcasting, which signifies producing or listening to digital audio on that very same portable device."

Archives

At the Zeitgeist Archives (www.google.com/press/zeitgeist/archive.html), you'll be able to jump from year to year. Within each year, you'll get the weekly lists, monthly Zeitgeists, and the year-end Zeitgeist, as explained.

What It All Means

So how far does the Google Zeitgeist capture the "real" Zeitgeist, as it were? We think it does so better than, for example, what you get in a newspaper or magazine at year-end! We'll justify that statement with the following.

- In print media "Zeitgeists," someone chooses what figures and what won't. At Google, the people have voted—and in massive numbers.
- If an issue has plagued (or taken by storm, or generally interested) a certain region and no other, that will show up in Google. For example, Hurricane Rita is unlikely to be showcased heavily in a Japanese year-end magazine column; at Google, you'll find a lot of mention of the hurricane for the year it occurred in.
- For each month, Google doesn't randomly compile a listing of searches: like we said, the categories for August are different from the categories for July. So, you get the idea that in August, a lot of female singers were searched for, and that in July, the word "Web 2.0" and all about the concept was gaining in importance and interest.

Collate for yourself the monthly reports, and you'll see trends and patterns no newspaper can give you.

- You'd need to stop over at Frankfurt airport in December and get yourselves a copy of *Die Welt* to figure out what people in Germany obsessed over in 2005. Your local paper won't report that. At Google, you can see year-end Zeitgeists for several countries—pick one that interests you.
- You'll get real, sometimes useful information. Who'd think that people in *India*—more than people in any other country—were interested in the US Open in August 2005 (the month of the US Open)? In the US, they were searching for football and basket-